

Whistler + Canadian Rockies

AUGUST 18 - 27, 2026 · SUV + AIRBNBS · 10 DAYS

Fly in	Fly out	Parks	Highlights	Pursuit Pass	Rental
Vancouver YVR · Aug 18	Calgary YYC · Aug 27	Banff · Yoho · Jasper	Whistler · Sea to Sky · Icefields Pkwy	All 5 attractions	One-way YVR → YYC

BASES

2 NIGHTS Whistler, BC Aug 18 - 20 Whistler Village or Creekside. Book ahead — August is peak season and fills fast.	1 NIGHT Revelstoke, BC Aug 20 - 21 Walkable mountain town between Mt Revelstoke and Glacier National Parks. Good food, craft beer, Columbia River views.	3 NIGHTS Canmore, AB Aug 21 - 24 Bow Valley base for Moraine Lake, Lake Louise, and Banff. Prefer downtown or Bow River area.	2 NIGHTS Jasper area, AB Aug 24 - 26 Pyramid Lake Resort, Tekarra Lodge, Pine Bungalows, Overlander Mountain Lodge	1 NIGHT Canmore, AB Aug 26 - 27 Final night before flying home from Calgary. Downtown Canmore walk, celebratory dinner.
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DAY BY DAY

1 DAY	Sunday, Aug 18	► DRIVE ► WALK
Arrive Vancouver → Sea to Sky → Whistler		
BASE: WHISTLER, BC · DRIVE: ~2 HRS VANCOUVER → WHISTLER		
ARRIVE	Land at Vancouver YVR — pick up your one-way rental SUV. The car return is Calgary YYC at the end of the trip.	
ON THE ROAD	Drive Sea to Sky Highway (Hwy 99) north toward Whistler — 125 km, one of Canada's best coastal mountain drives. The road rises out of the city through rainforest, hugs the ocean at Horseshoe Bay, then climbs past granite cliffs into the mountains. Keep eyes open for bears and eagles.	
EN ROUTE	Shannon Falls (Squamish) — quick 10-min pull-off to a 335m waterfall, the third highest in BC. Right off the highway. Optional: view of Stawamus Chief , a massive granite monolith above Squamish.	
AFTERNOON	Arrive Whistler . Check in. Walk the Village Stroll — the car-free pedestrian village at the base of both mountains. Restaurants, shops, alpine atmosphere. Get your bearings and pick up any supplies.	
DINNER	<i>Araxi Restaurant</i> (upscale, iconic Whistler), <i>Quattro</i> (Italian, courtyard), or <i>The Wildflower</i> at the Fairmont Chateau Whistler.	
TONIGHT	Book Whistler Gondola + Peak 2 Peak for tomorrow if not already reserved — whistlerblackcomb.com . Book a morning slot. Summer operations run daily through August.	
	► Hwy 99 between Squamish and Whistler is breathtaking but has no services — fill the tank before you leave Vancouver. The drive is only 2 hours but you'll want to stop for photos.	

2 DAY	Monday, Aug 19	★ GONDOLA ► WALK
Whistler — Peak 2 Peak & The Village		
BASE: WHISTLER, BC		
8:00 AM	Breakfast — <i>Purebread</i> (best bakery in Whistler, lineup worth it), <i>Tractor Everyday Food</i> , or your hotel. Fuel up.	
9:00 AM	Whistler Gondola — ride up to Whistler Mountain (Roundhouse Lodge, 1,850m). Views of the glacier, peaks, and valley open up as you ascend. Walk around the Roundhouse area — grab a coffee with a view.	
10:00 AM	Peak 2 Peak Gondola DON'T MISS — the signature Whistler experience. A 4.4 km cable car connects Whistler Mountain to Blackcomb Mountain, spanning a world-record 3 km open span 436 m above the valley floor. The views of glaciers, alpine meadows, and the valley are extraordinary. Allow 45-60 min for the crossing and back (or stay on Blackcomb).	
11:00 AM	Blackcomb Mountain summit — Horstman Glacier viewpoint is an easy 10-min walk from the top station. The glacier sits at 2,440m and is still skiable in summer. The alpine meadow views are as good as anything you'll see in the Rockies.	
12:30 PM	Ride gondola back down to Whistler Village. Lunch — <i>21 Steps Kitchen</i> (rooftop patio) or <i>La Cantina</i> (tacos in the village). Pick up trail snacks at a grocery for tomorrow's long drive.	
2:00 PM	Valley Trail — the 40 km paved trail network connects Whistler's neighbourhoods through forest and along Lost Lake. Walk or rent bikes (15-30 min is enough for a taste). Flat, easy, beautiful.	
3:30 PM	Optional: Audain Art Museum (45 min) — world-class collection of Northwest Coast Indigenous art and BC landscape painting. One of the best small art museums in Canada.	
6:30 PM	Dinner — <i>Alta Bistro</i> (farm-to-table, excellent), <i>Peaked Pies</i> (Australian meat pies, casual), or back to Araxi if you didn't go last night.	

BEFORE BED **Set your alarm for 6:50 am tomorrow** **CRITICAL ACTION** — Moraine Lake shuttles for Aug 22 open on **Aug 20 at 7:00 am PDT (= 8:00 am MDT)**. You must book the moment slots open at [reservation.pc.gc.ca](#). Target the 9:30 am departure from Lake Louise Park & Ride. Do not miss this window.

► Peak 2 Peak tickets: book in advance at [whistlerblackcomb.com](#) (the gondola combo is around CA\$85/person in summer). Morning is best — cloud can roll in by afternoon.

3
DAY

Tuesday, Aug 20

Whistler → Revelstoke — The BC Interior Drive

► DRIVE

BASE: REVELSTOKE, BC · DRIVE: ~6 HRS WHISTLER → REVELSTOKE

- 6:50 AM

BOOK MORaine LAKE SHUTTLE NOW **DO THIS FIRST** — Aug 22 slots open today at 7:00 am PDT. Go to [reservation.pc.gc.ca](#) and book the 9:30 am departure from Lake Louise Park & Ride for Aug 22. Slots go in minutes.
- 8:00 AM

Breakfast — grab pastries from *Purebread* to go, or a quick sit-down at your hotel. Pack snacks and fill water bottles; services are limited through the BC interior.
- 8:30 AM

Depart Whistler north on **Hwy 99** through Pemberton — the valley opens up into ranch land backed by enormous peaks. A completely different landscape from yesterday. Continue toward Lillooet, then Cache Creek.
- 10:00 AM

Optional: **Nairn Falls** (Pemberton, 15-min stop) — short trail to a powerful waterfall on the Lillooet River. Worth it if energy is up; skip if you want to make time.
- 12:00 PM

Lunch in **Kamloops** or Cache Creek — practical fuel stop. Kamloops has good options including downtown restaurants on the Thompson River.
- 1:00 PM

East on the **Trans-Canada (Hwy 1)** through the Thompson River canyon and into the Columbia Mountains. The terrain shifts from dry grassland to dramatic forested gorges as you approach Revelstoke. Eagle Pass crossing is spectacular.
- 4:00 PM

Arrive **Revelstoke**. Check in. This is a proper mountain town on the Columbia River, wedged between Mt Revelstoke National Park to the north and Glacier National Park to the east. The main street is walkable with excellent food.
- 5:30 PM

Walk **Revelstoke's Victoria Road** — the compact main street. Pick up any groceries or trail snacks needed for the next few days of Alberta driving.
- 7:00 PM

Dinner — *Quartermaster Restaurant*, *La Baguette* (French bistro), or *Dose Coffee & Tap* (craft beer, casual).

► Today is a long drive day — build in flexibility. The scenery through the BC interior is genuinely beautiful (Thompson River canyon, Columbia River valley, Eagle Pass) but this is windshield time, not stop-and-explore time. Good podcasts/playlist day.

4
DAY

Wednesday, Aug 21

Revelstoke → Golden Skybridge → Yoho → Canmore

★ ACTIVITY

► WALK

► DRIVE

MOVE TO: CANMORE, AB · DRIVE: ~4.5 HRS MOVING, STOPS ADD ~3 HRS

- 8:00 AM

Breakfast in Revelstoke — *Conversations Coffee* or *Dose*. Check out.
- 8:30 AM

Drive east on **Trans-Canada (Hwy 1)** through **Glacier National Park** — Rogers Pass. Dramatic mountain scenery as the highway crests the pass at 1,330m. No need to stop (save time), but the drive through the pass is itself excellent. ~1.5 hrs to Golden.
- 10:00 AM

Golden Skybridge **PURSUIT PASS** — two suspension bridges spanning a deep canyon above the Columbia River with Rocky Mountain views. The longer bridge is among the highest in North America. The shorter bridge has a zip line option if anyone is feeling brave. Allow 90 min. Book your time slot at [goldenbc.ca/skybridge](#).
- 11:30 AM

Continue east on Trans-Canada into **Yoho National Park** (Field, BC). You've crossed into the Alberta Rockies geological zone — the peaks change character immediately.
- 12:00 PM

Spiral Tunnels viewpoint — quick pull-off above Field on the Trans-Canada. The CPR railway loops through the mountains in a double figure-eight spiral to safely descend the grade. If a freight train is actively passing through, it's extraordinary engineering in dramatic scenery. 10 min stop.
- 12:15 PM

Natural Bridge — 10-min stop. The Kicking Horse River has carved through solid quartzite, forming a natural arch with brilliant glacial green water rushing beneath. Just off the road near the Emerald Lake junction.
- 12:30 PM

Emerald Lake — the most intensely coloured lake in Yoho. A deep tropical green ringed by forest and the President Range. Lunch at *Emerald Lake Lodge* restaurant (dining room, or grab from the café) or your own picnic. Short lakeshore walk (30 min, flat). Canoe rentals if anyone wants to paddle.
- 2:30 PM

Continue east on Trans-Canada through Lake Louise and east to Canmore. 2 hrs.
- 4:30 PM

Arrive **Canmore**. Check in — three nights here. Drop bags, walk downtown along the creek.
- 6:30 PM

Dinner — *Crazyweed Kitchen* or *Rocky Mountain Flatbread*.

► Yoho is a perfect drive-through park — the best stops are right off the road or a few minutes' walk. Don't try to do Takakkaw Falls today (Yoho Valley Road adds 30 min each way) — save your energy for tomorrow.

5
DAY

Thursday, Aug 22

Moraine Lake & Lake Louise — The Iconic Day

► SHUTTLE

► WALK

BASE: CANMORE, AB

- 8:00 AM

Breakfast at Airbnb or *Communitéa*. Pack snacks and water — no food at Moraine Lake itself.

8:30 AM	Drive to Lake Louise Park & Ride (~45 min from Canmore). Personal vehicles are not permitted at Moraine Lake or Lake Louise — all visitors use shuttles.
9:15 AM	Lake Louise Park & Ride — park here (free with shuttle reservation). Board the shuttle to Moraine Lake.
9:30 AM	Shuttle departs for Moraine Lake .
10:00 AM	Arrive Moraine Lake — one of the most intense lake-and-peak scenes on the planet. The Valley of the Ten Peaks rises directly above a deep turquoise lake fed by glacial meltwater. Walk the Rockpile trail (15 min, 30m gain) for the elevated postcard view. Spend time at the lakeshore. It is as good as it looks.
1:00 PM	Shuttle back to Park & Ride. Board Lake Louise shuttle.
1:30 PM	Lake Louise — the classic glacier lake beneath Victoria Glacier. Walk the flat lakeshore trail (~1 hr loop). Lunch at the <i>Fairmont Lake Louise</i> Lakeview Lounge terrace or picnic on the shore. The afternoon light hits the Fairmont façade beautifully.
4:00 PM	Shuttle back. Drive to Canmore (~45 min).
5:30 PM	Canmore townsite walk — Bow River pedestrian bridge , Three Sisters view from downtown. Best mountain backdrop in town.
6:30 PM	Dinner — <i>Gaucha Brazilian BBQ</i> (all-you-can-eat churrasqueira) or <i>The Blake</i> (upscale, excellent wine list).
► Shuttle slots were booked Aug 20 — you're set. Note that Moraine Lake is significantly more dramatic than Lake Louise; plan your best energy for the morning. The afternoon Lake Louise visit is gentler and great in softer light.	

6

DAY

Friday, Aug 23

Banff — Johnston Canyon & Gondola

► WALK

★ GONDOLA

BASE: CANMORE, AB

8:00 AM

Breakfast at Airbnb. Drive via **Bow Valley Parkway (Hwy 1A)** — the quiet, scenic alternative to the Trans-Canada. Slower, forested, better for wildlife sightings.

9:30 AM

Johnston Canyon — one of Banff's most accessible and dramatic walks. The paved canyon trail clings to the cliff face on metal catwalk suspended above the rushing Kicking Horse River. **Lower Falls** (1.1 km, 20 min, easy) — a turquoise curtain of water in a narrow slot canyon. **Upper Falls** (2.7 km from trailhead, 30 min more) — taller and wilder. Both together take about 1.5 hrs return. Do both.

11:15 AM

Drive to **Banff townsite** (20 min).

12:00 PM

Lunch in Banff — *Wild Flour Bakery* (sandwiches, excellent), *Balkan Restaurant* (Greek, casual), or *Juniper Bistro* (patio with mountain views).

1:30 PM

Banff Gondola **PURSUIT PASS** — 8-min gondola to the summit of Sulphur Mountain (2,281m). Walk the **Skywalk boardwalk** along the ridge (1.6 km, flat, 360° panorama). On a clear day you can see seven mountain ranges. Take the gondola back down. Allow 1.5 hrs.

3:30 PM

Vermilion Lakes — a 10-min drive west of Banff on Hwy 1A. Three shallow lakes reflecting Mt Rundle and the Banff townsite skyline. Classic mountain photography. Short flat walk or simply drive the road.

4:30 PM

Drive back to Canmore (20 min). Last night here — pack bags tonight for the Jasper move tomorrow.

6:30 PM

Dinner — *Brazen* (steakhouse, excellent) or *Rocky Mountain Flatbread* (wood-fired, family-friendly).

► Banff Gondola is included in the Pursuit Pass — no separate ticket needed. The Sulphur Mountain summit is cold even in August; bring a layer. Johnston Canyon is one of the few walks the entire crew will love regardless of fitness level.

7 DAY	Saturday, Aug 24	► DRIVE	► WALK
Canmore → Icefields Pkwy North → Jasper			
MOVE TO: JASPER AREA, AB · DRIVE: ~5 HRS WITH STOPS (CANMORE → JASPER VIA ICEFIELDS PKWY)			
8:00 AM	Breakfast at Airbnb. Check out. Pack for 2 nights in Jasper.		
8:30 AM	Drive north on Trans-Canada to Lake Louise (45 min), then north on Hwy 93 — Icefields Parkway . You'll drive it southbound fully on Day 9; today is a scenic transit north hitting the southern highlights.		
9:45 AM	Bow Lake — pull off, short walk to the lakeshore (15 min). Glaciers reflected in a flat alpine lake beneath Crowfoot Mountain. Classic Parkway view.		
10:10 AM	Peyto Lake viewpoint — paved walk (800m, 70m gain, 20 min). The wolf-head-shaped turquoise lake viewed from high above. One of the most photographed scenes in Canada.		
10:45 AM	Continue north. The Parkway climbs through increasingly dramatic terrain — Weeping Wall, Big Bend, Columbia Icefield approach.		
12:00 PM	Lunch at Columbia Icefield Discovery Centre cafeteria (only food option on the Parkway). From the parking area, you can see the toe of the Athabasca Glacier from the road — a free taste of what Day 9 holds. Allow 45 min.		
1:00 PM	Continue north. Sunwapta Valley, Sunwapta Falls viewpoint (save the stop for Day 9 southbound).		
2:30 PM	Athabasca Falls — just south of Jasper. 10-min walk to the falls where the Athabasca River plunges through a narrow quartzite gorge. Powerful and close — among the most impressive short stops in Jasper.		
3:00 PM	Detour onto Hwy 93A south → Edith Cavell Road (14 km winding mountain road). Park at the trailhead. Walk the Path of the Glacier (1.6 km loop, flat, 30 min) — a remarkable short walk across a glacial moraine with Angel Glacier hanging above. Interpretive markers show the ice retreat decade by decade. No hike required — all the drama is right there.		
5:00 PM	Arrive Jasper townsite. Check in to your cabin or lodge.		
7:00 PM	Dinner — <i>Downstream Bar & Grill</i> (classic Jasper) or <i>Terra Restaurant</i> (upscale, locally sourced).		

► You'll drive the Icefields Pkwy in both directions across the trip — northbound today hits the southern scenic viewpoints (Bow Lake, Peyto); southbound on Day 9 focuses on the glacier activities (Icefield Adventure, Skywalk, Sunwapta). They feel like genuinely different experiences.

8
DAY

Sunday, Aug 25
Jasper — Maligne Lake & Spirit Island Cruise

CRUISE

WALK

BASE: JASPER AREA, AB

- 8:00 AM

Breakfast at *Bear's Paw Bakery* in Jasper townsite (legendary cinnamon buns and coffee) or at your cabin. Pack snacks.
- 8:30 AM

Drive **Maligne Road** (48 km, ~50 min) along Maligne Canyon and toward the largest natural lake in the Canadian Rockies.
- 9:30 AM

Arrive **Maligne Lake**.
- 10:00 AM

Spirit Island Boat Cruise **PURSUIT PASS** — a 90-min narrated cruise on Maligne Lake's emerald-green water to **Spirit Island**, a tiny forested island in the shadow of serrated glacier peaks. One of the most iconic views in Canada. Book ahead at [malignelake.com](#). Pursuit Pass covers this.
- 11:30 AM

Back at the dock. Walk the **lakeside trail** (flat, easy, 20 min each direction). The lake stretches 22 km into the mountains — you can see it all from the trailhead.
- 12:30 PM

Drive back to Jasper (50 min).
- 1:30 PM

Lunch in Jasper townsite — *Coco's Café* (excellent coffee and food), *Jasper Brewing Co.* (pub food and local beer), or *Patricia Street Deli* (quick and good).
- 3:00 PM

Pyramid Lake — 7 km north of Jasper on Pyramid Lake Road. Walk the causeway to **Pyramid Island** (flat, 15 min), a small island connected to the lakeshore by a wooden bridge. The lake perfectly reflects Pyramid Mountain. Canoe and kayak rentals available at the resort dock.
- 4:30 PM

Optional: **Miette Hot Springs** — the hottest natural hot springs in the Canadian Rockies (54°C at source, cooled for the pools). 63 km round trip from Jasper. Perfect if anyone wants to soak after the cruise day. Bring a bathing suit.
- 7:00 PM

Final Jasper dinner — *Fiddle River Restaurant* (seafood and game, excellent) or *Something Else Restaurant* (Greek-Canadian, local favourite). Pack bags tonight for checkout tomorrow.

► Maligne Lake cruise is the best single Jasper activity for a group that wants dramatic scenery without a long hike. The Spirit Island view is worth it. Book the cruise in advance — August slots fill up. If you book Miette Hot Springs, note it closes at 9pm in summer.

9
DAY

Monday, Aug 26
Icefields Parkway — Jasper to Canmore

★ ACTIVITY

WALK

DRIVE

MOVE TO: CANMORE, AB · DRIVE: 5–6 HRS MOVING, ALL DAY WITH STOPS

- 8:00 AM

Breakfast at cabin or *Bear's Paw Bakery*. Pack snacks and water for the road — the Columbia Icefield cafeteria is the only real lunch stop on the Parkway today.
- 8:30 AM

Check out. Drive south on **Icefields Parkway (Hwy 93S)** — 230 km of the greatest mountain drive on earth. Today you cover the heart of it: the glacier section.
- 10:30 AM

Sunwapta Falls — quick 15-min stop. A powerful two-tiered canyon waterfall where the Sunwapta River plunges through turquoise rock. Just off the Parkway south of Jasper.
- 12:00 PM

Lunch at the **Columbia Icefield Discovery Centre** cafeteria. Basic but it's the only food on the Parkway. Fuel up.
- 1:00 PM

Columbia Icefield Adventure **PURSUIT PASS** — board a massive Ice Explorer all-terrain vehicle and ride out onto the surface of the **Athabasca Glacier**. You step off and walk on ice that is 300 years old and 300 m thick. This is a fundamentally different experience from viewing the glacier from the road. Allow 1.5 hrs. Book your departure time slot in advance at [banffjaspercollection.com](#) — required even with Pursuit Pass.
- 2:30 PM

Columbia Icefield Skywalk **PURSUIT PASS** — a glass-floored platform cantilevered 280 m above the Sunwapta Valley, a short drive south of the Icefield Centre. Interpretive trail explains the glacier geology. Allow 45 min.
- 4:00 PM

Continue south. Bow Lake and Peyto Lake already visited northbound on Day 7 — continue through to Canmore without stopping (or a quick photo stop if desired).
- 5:30 PM

Drive through Lake Louise, Trans-Canada east to **Canmore** (~1 hr from Bow Lake). Check in — one final night.
- 7:00 PM

Celebratory dinner — *Tavern 1883* or *The Blake*. Final walk along the Bow River pedestrian bridge. The trip is complete.

► Non-negotiables today: Icefield Adventure, Skywalk. Book the Adventure time slot well in advance — it fills independently of the Pursuit Pass. If running late, Skywalk can be done quickly (45 min). Bow Lake and Peyto are already checked off from Day 7.

10
DAY

Tuesday, Aug 27
Canmore → Calgary → Fly Home

DRIVE

RETURN · DRIVE: 1 HR CANMORE → CALGARY YYC

- 8:00 AM

Breakfast in Canmore — *Beamer's Coffee Bar* or *Communithea Café*. Last morning with the Three Sisters skyline.
- 9:30 AM

Check out. Drive Trans-Canada east to Calgary (~1 hr).
- 10:30 AM

Arrive **Calgary YYC**. Return the rental car (one-way drop-off, Vancouver pick-up). Check in for your flight home.

► The one-way rental drop-off is at Calgary YYC. Confirm the exact return location with your rental company in advance — some agencies use an off-airport lot requiring a shuttle.

WHAT TO BOOK — AND WHEN

Item	When to Book	Where	Notes
Whistler accommodation	Now	VRBO, Airbnb, or whistlerblackcomb.com	August is absolute peak season. Whistler Village or Creekside. Book immediately.
Revelstoke accommodation	Now	Booking.com / Airbnb	1 night (Aug 20). Options include Regent Hotel, Coast Hillcrest, or local B&Bs.
Canmore accommodation (first stay)	Now	Airbnb or hotels	3 nights (Aug 21–24). Downtown or Bow River area preferred.
Jasper accommodation	Now	Direct with property	2 nights (Aug 24–26). Options: Pyramid Lake Resort, Tekarra Lodge, Pine Bungalows, Overlander Mountain Lodge.
Canmore accommodation (return)	Now	Airbnb or hotels	1 night (Aug 26–27). Can be anywhere in town.
One-way rental car	Now	Enterprise, National, Hertz	Pick up Vancouver YVR, drop off Calgary YYC. Call directly for best one-way rates. Book an SUV.
Pursuit Pass Rockies	Now	banffjaspercollection.com	CA\$339/adult. Covers all 5: Golden Skybridge, Banff Gondola, Maligne Lake Cruise, Icefield Adventure, Icefield Skywalk.
Whistler Gondola + Peak 2 Peak	Now	whistlerblackcomb.com	Book the Day 2 morning slot. Summer sightseeing combo ~CA\$85/person. Sells out in peak weeks.
Parks Canada Discovery Pass	Before trip	reservation.pc.gc.ca	~CA\$75/adult or CA\$150 family (unlimited). Covers Banff, Yoho, and Jasper park entry fees — pays for itself by Day 4.
Golden Skybridge time slot	Before trip	goldenbc.ca/skybridge	Covered by Pursuit Pass. Book the 10:00 am slot for Day 4 (Aug 21).
Moraine Lake shuttle	Aug 20 at 7:00 am PDT	reservation.pc.gc.ca	Rolling 2-day window — Aug 22 slots open Aug 20 at 8:00 am MDT (= 7:00 am PDT). Set alarm for 6:50 am PDT. Book 9:30 am departure from Lake Louise Park & Ride.
Maligne Lake Spirit Island Cruise	Before trip	malignelake.com	Included in Pursuit Pass. Book a 10:00 am slot for Day 8 (Aug 25).
Columbia Icefield Adventure time slot	Before trip	banffjaspercollection.com	Covered by Pursuit Pass but requires a separate time slot booking. Book 1:00 pm for Day 9 (Aug 26).

GOOD TO KNOW

THE FLOW OF THIS TRIP

You arrive on BC's coast and the scenery builds progressively: rainforest and granite cliffs (Sea to Sky), resort mountains (Whistler), dry interior valleys (BC interior), then Columbia Mountain passes (Revelstoke, Rogers Pass), and finally the full Rocky Mountain grandeur from Banff to Jasper. It escalates. By the time you reach Moraine Lake and the Icefields Parkway, the buildup pays off.

WHISTLER IN AUGUST

August is peak hiking and biking season but the gondola and Peak 2 Peak are the headline activities for sightseeing visitors. Afternoon cloud is common — do the summit activities in the morning. Whistler Village is pedestrian-only and extremely walkable. Parking is at the Day Lots at the base of both mountains. Your hotel may have shuttle service from the village.

DRIVING THE ICEFIELDS PARKWAY

You drive the Parkway in both directions: northbound on Day 7 (Bow Lake, Peyto Lake), southbound on Day 9 (Sunwapta Falls, Icefield Adventure, Skywalk). Both directions have different angles and lighting. Gas up in Lake Louise before going north and in Jasper before heading south — there are no gas stations on the Parkway itself.

WILDLIFE

Bears (black and grizzly), elk, moose, bighorn sheep, and mountain goats are genuinely common across this route. Pull over safely if you see a wildlife jam on the highway — never stop in the lane. Keep food secured in your vehicle at all

ONE-WAY RENTAL ADVICE

One-way fees from Vancouver YVR to Calgary YYC vary widely by company and how far in advance you book. Call Enterprise, National, and Hertz directly — they sometimes have better one-way rates over the phone than online. Confirm the exact drop-off location at YYC, as off-airport lots require a shuttle. Budget 30 extra minutes at the Calgary end.

CROSSING INTO ALBERTA

You enter Alberta on Day 4 via the Trans-Canada near Field, BC (Yoho NP). The landscape changes noticeably — the peaks become more dramatic and the rock layers exposed in the thrust fault geology are extraordinary. If your Parks Canada Discovery Pass isn't purchased before the trip, you can buy it at any park gate. Keep it in the windshield for all subsequent park entry.

WHAT TO PACK

Layers every day — mornings are cold even in August (0–8°C at altitude). Rain shell essential (Whistler gets coastal weather). Sunscreen and sunglasses (UV is intense at elevation). Good walking shoes with grip (some paths are rocky). Bathing suit for Miette Hot Springs. Binoculars help for glacier and wildlife viewing.

MALIGNE LAKE CRUISE TIP

The Spirit Island view is accessible only by the 90-min boat cruise — there is no trail to Spirit Island. The landscape on the water is extraordinary on calm mornings when the lake mirrors the peaks. Bring a warm layer; the lake is at

times, especially overnight in Jasper and Whistler. Bear spray is available at any outdoor store in Canmore or Jasper.

1,700m and the boat deck is exposed. If weather is uncertain on your planned day, verify cancellation policies when booking.